

II9

Joseph of Nazareth

The quiet, just man who took Mary as his wife, named her Son, and protected him.

Joseph was a descendant of King David who worked with his hands in Nazareth. Engaged to Mary, he learned she was expecting a child that was not his. Matthew calls him "a just man," and he planned to end the engagement quietly. Then an angel spoke to him in a dream, and he obeyed at once. Joseph speaks no recorded word, yet his actions say a great deal. He took Mary home, named the child Jesus, fled to Egypt to escape Herod, and raised Jesus as his own. His life shows faith that listens, obeys and protects without seeking attention.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yoseph</i> , "he will add" or "may he add"
Family	"Joseph, thou son of David" (Matt 1:20); husband of Mary
Trade	"The carpenter's son" (Matt 13:55); builder or craftsman
When	c. 7–4 BC for the birth stories; last seen when Jesus was twelve
Key places	Nazareth, Bethlehem, Egypt, Jerusalem
Key people	Mary, mother of Jesus; Herod the Great; Simeon and Anna
Main passages	Matthew 1:18–2:23; Luke 1:27; 2:1–51

"Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife."

Matthew 1:24, KJV

The life of Joseph of Nazareth

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Scripture gives no age for Joseph and does not record his death.

c. 7–5 BC

In Nazareth

● The first dream

Joseph learns Mary is with child and decides to end the engagement privately. An angel tells him in a dream not to fear, because the child is of the Holy Ghost. He takes Mary as his wife. *Matthew 1:18–25*

c. 6–4 BC

Bethlehem

● The census and the birth

Because he is of David's house, Joseph travels with Mary to Bethlehem to be registered. There Jesus is born, and Joseph gives him the name Jesus. *Luke 2:1–7; Matthew 1:25*

c. 6–4 BC

Forty days

● In the temple

Joseph and Mary present Jesus to the Lord. They marvel at Simeon's words, and Simeon blesses them. *Luke 2:22–35*

c. 6–4 BC

By night

● Flight into Egypt

After the wise men leave, an angel warns Joseph in a dream to flee because Herod will seek the child. Joseph rises that night and takes the family to Egypt. *Matthew 2:13–15*

c. 4 BC

After Herod dies

● Home to Nazareth

Told in a dream that Herod is dead, Joseph returns. Hearing that Archelaus rules Judaea, he is afraid and, warned again, settles in Nazareth in Galilee. *Matthew 2:19–23*

Jesus aged 12

● The last scene

On the yearly Passover trip, Joseph and Mary lose Jesus and search for three days before finding him in the temple. *Luke 2:41–51*

Key activities

Scripture records no words spoken by Joseph. Many infer that he died before Jesus' public ministry, since he never appears in it, but the text does not say.

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- 1 Chose mercy.** Before the dream, he planned to end the engagement quietly rather than shame Mary. *Matthew 1:19*
 - 2 Obeyed the first dream.** He took Mary as his wife and did not come together with her until the child was born. *Matthew 1:20-25*
 - 3 Named the child.** As the angel said, he called him "JESUS: for he shall save his people from their sins." *Matthew 1:21, 25*
 - 4 Went to Bethlehem.** He travelled with Mary to the city of David to be taxed, as the emperor's decree required. *Luke 2:4-5*
 - 5 Kept the Law of Moses.** He and Mary presented Jesus in the temple and offered two birds. *Luke 2:22-24*
 - 6 Protected his family.** Warned in dreams, he fled to Egypt, returned after Herod's death, and chose Nazareth for safety. *Matthew 2:13-23*
 - 7 Led the family in worship.** Every year he and Mary went up to Jerusalem for Passover. *Luke 2:41-42*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Tradition, not Scripture: some early writings make Joseph an older widower with children.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:12-16	Joseph gives Jesus his legal place in David's line
Hosea 11:1	"Out of Egypt," fulfilled in Jesus' return (Matthew 2:15)
Echo: Genesis 37:5-11; 45:5	Like Jacob's Joseph: dreams, Egypt, preserving life

New Testament

Matthew 1:16; Luke 3:23	Both genealogies run through Joseph; they differ
Luke 4:22; John 1:45; 6:42	Jesus called "the son of Joseph"
Matthew 13:55	"Is not this the carpenter's son?"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Joseph decide to do before the angel spoke to him (Matthew 1:19)?
2. *Understand:* Matthew calls Joseph "a just man." How does his plan show both justice and mercy?
3. *Apply:* Joseph obeyed quickly, even at night. What makes it hard for you to act promptly on what you know God wants?
4. *Apply:* Joseph protected those in his care without being noticed. Who could you quietly serve or protect this month?